

THE BRAIN BRAKE

VERSION FIVE · THE MENTOR · 11.8.2026 · FOR NEHA

What changed

The film has been rebuilt around Manan. He is on camera in all six scenes, speaking, in his own room. The animation now supports him instead of carrying the film. That moves the work, and the budget, from the animator to the shoot.

Why. I went back through the winning entries and the official judging criteria properly. Four things are scored equally: engagement, illumination, creativity and difficulty. Illumination asks whether the viewer genuinely understood the idea. The judges are reading the student, not the production. A previous winner recommends the student be on screen for at least forty percent of the running time, because entries that show their creator do measurably better. The version I had been building had Manan on screen for about eight seconds out of a hundred and twenty. That was my error and I have corrected it.

The formula the winners use

One. The student is the film. Face, voice, room, personality. Not a narrator over graphics.

Two. One idea, explained cleanly, with the hard part made visible rather than skipped.

Three. A real question at the top that the film actually answers by the end.

Four. Simple visuals used as evidence, not decoration. A demonstration beats an illustration.

Five. Honest about what is still debated. Judges reward that and are unimpressed by overselling.

The film in six scenes

	SCENE	TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
1	THE CALL	0:00–0:18	Manan in his room. He plays a clip of a finished runner who suddenly sprints, and asks where that came from.
2	THE OLD MASTER	0:18–0:40	He opens a book. The 1923 answer, drawn, rises from the page. The muscle runs out of oxygen. Good answer, not a complete one.
3	WHAT DOES NOT FIT	0:40–0:58	The drawn runner leaves the page and speeds up across his desk. The old curve cannot allow that.
4	THE MENTOR	0:58–1:25	A small cartoon brain in a tracksuit steps off the page with a coffee. I run the brakes. So you stop me. I finish you.
5	THE LESSON	1:25–1:48	The lever goes to ninety five and never to a hundred. Then Manan reaches in and moves it himself.
6	THE RETURN	1:48–2:00	Alone, to camera, in his own words. Fatigue is not failure, it is protection. The wall is real, but somebody built it.

The shoot

Everything with Manan is filmed. The drawn elements are added afterwards, so on the day he is performing to an empty desk in a few places and Venkatesh and I will guide him through it.

DAY	SETUP	WHAT WE SHOOT	HOURS
1	His room, wide and mid	Scenes 1, 2 and 6. Manan at his desk to camera, the laptop, the book. This is the spine of the film and most of the dialogue.	4
1	His room, close	Reaction closes for every scene. Faces carry this film.	2
2	Desk top, overhead and low	Scenes 3, 4 and 5. The empty desk, his hands, his finger on the page, his hand reaching for the lever that is not there yet.	3
2	Pick ups and safety	Anything we want twice, plus a clean plate of the desk and the room for the animator.	2

Two days, about eleven hours of camera time. Both can be in Manan's own room, which is better than a studio because it is his. He needs one plain t shirt or hoodie he is comfortable in, and to know his lines well enough to forget them.

What this means for the budget

Hand drawn animation is the expensive part of any film like this, and the previous version was almost entirely animation. This version is mostly camera. Venkatesh costs considerably less per day than an animator does, and the animation that remains is a small cast of drawn elements on a desk rather than a fully drawn world.

So the money moves from Zagreb to Pondicherry, and the total should come down rather than up. I will send you exact figures once Venkatesh confirms his two days and the animator re quotes against this version.

What I need from you

- Two days with Manan and Venkatesh, ideally close together. Which dates work.
- Confirmation that we can film in his room, and that it can be quiet for recording.
- Whether Manan is comfortable speaking to camera, or whether we should build in extra time for that.
- Anything in the six scenes above that does not sound like him. His voice has to be his.

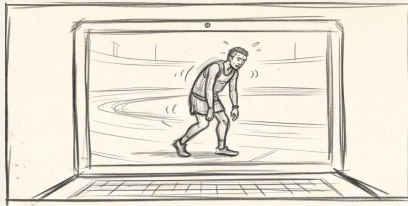
The film on paper

One panel per shot, thirty six in all. The full board with every line of dialogue is on the production site.

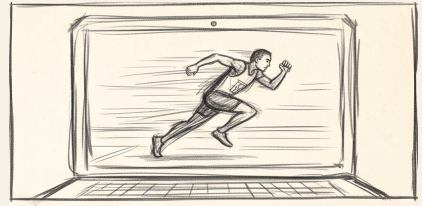
SCENE 1 · THE CALL



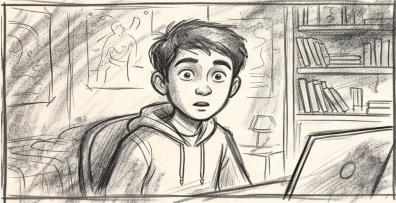
ACTION: MANAN AT DESK, TALKING TO



ACTION: LAPTOP SCREEN: MARATHON RUNNER



ACTION: LAPTOP SCREEN: RUNNER SUDDENLY



ACTION: MANAN TURNS BACK TO CAMERA,



ACTION: CLOSE-UP ON MANAN, GESTURING

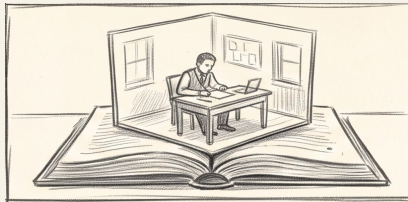


ACTION: MANAN REACHES FOR A BOOK

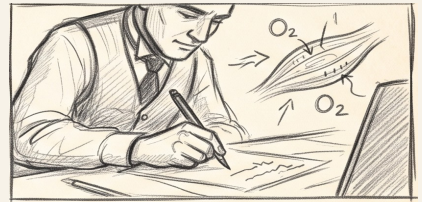
SCENE 2 · THE OLD MASTER



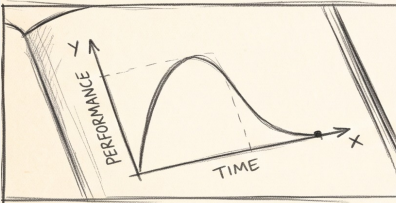
ACTION: MANAN AT DESK, OPENING AN OLD



ACTION: THE BOOK OPEN; A SMALL DRAWN



ACTION: CLOSE-UP ON THE DRAWN MAN AT



ACTION: A SIMPLE GRAPHICAL CURVE RISE

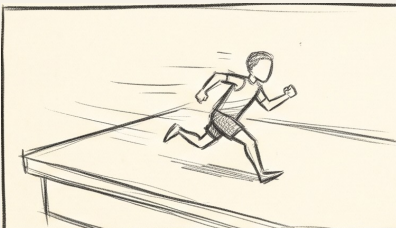
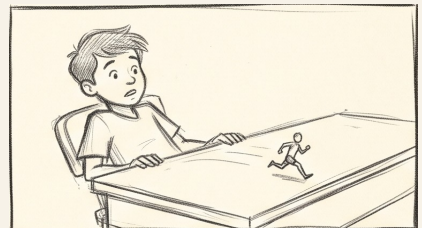
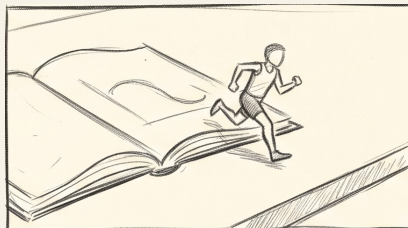
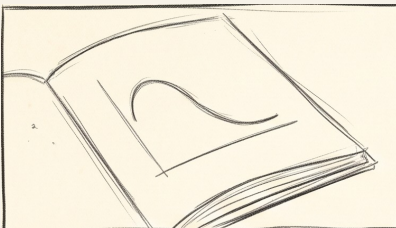


ACTION: MANAN NODS, A GESTURE OF

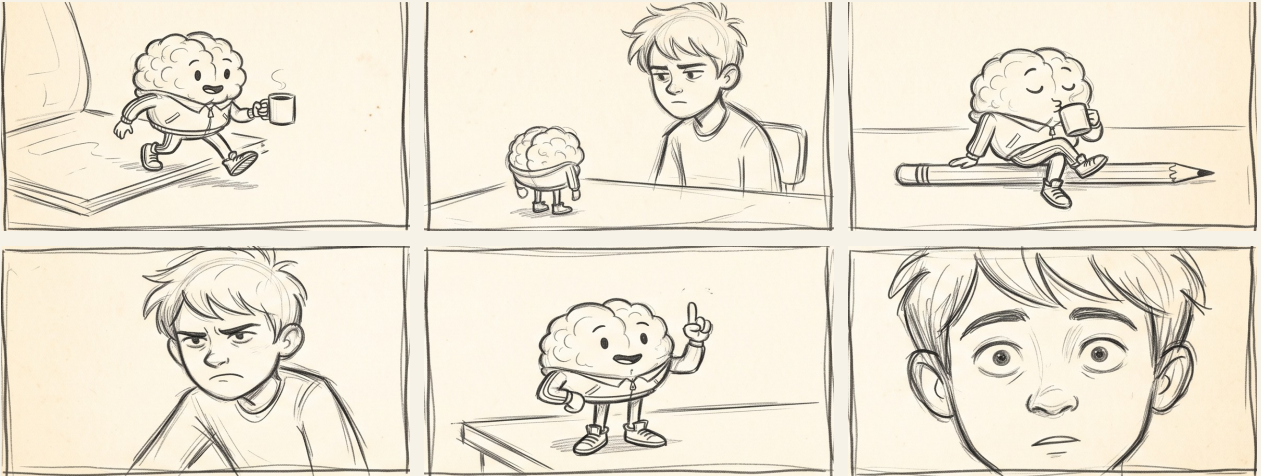


ACTION: MANAN'S FACE CLOSER, A WAVE OF

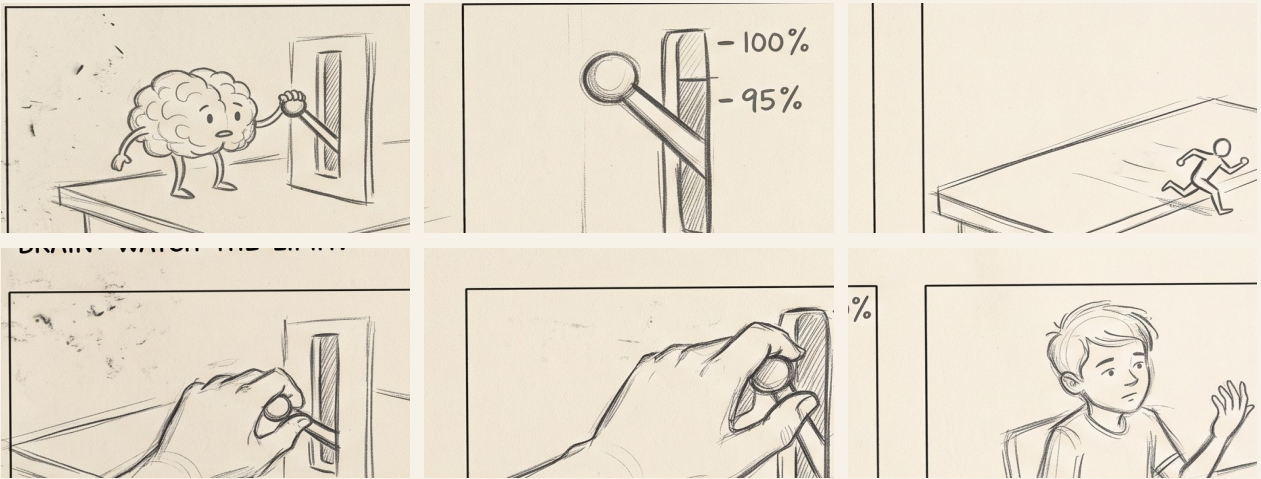
SCENE 3 · WHAT DOES NOT FIT



SCENE 4 • THE MENTOR



SCENE 5 • THE LESSON



SCENE 6 • THE RETURN

